

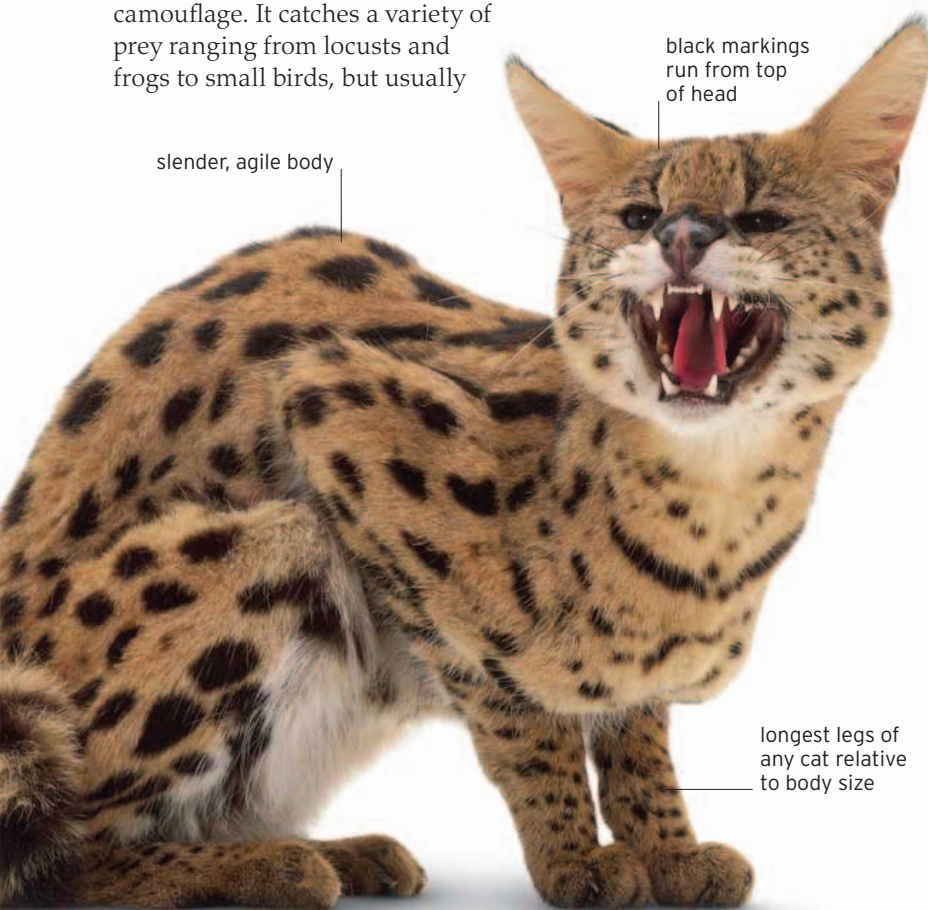
Serval

Leptailurus serval

- ↔ 24–39 in (61–100 cm)
- 📍 Africa
- ⊗ Common

Lean and long-legged like a small cheetah, the serval often hunts among the tall reeds and rushes of wetlands, where its dark-spotted, yellowish coat provides excellent camouflage. It catches a variety of prey ranging from locusts and frogs to small birds, but usually

targets rats and other rodents. The serval, one of the tallest cats, detects much of its prey with its long, mobile ears, but also uses its height to see over tall vegetation. The females bear an average litter of two young after a 73-day gestation period.



Sand cat

Felis margarita

- ↔ 18–23 in (46–58 cm)
- 📍 N. Africa, W., C., and SW. Asia
- ⊗ Near threatened

This small, short-legged, blunt-clawed, sandy gray cat is adapted for life in the desert. It digs or takes over a burrow in the sand for shelter from the scorching sun by day and hunts at night—mainly for rodents such as gerbils and jerboas, although it also takes lizards, snakes, and a few insects. It gets most of the moisture it needs from its prey, so it does not need to live near a water source.



Fishing cat

Prionailurus viverrinus

- ↔ 30–34 in (75–86 cm)
- 📍 S. to SE. Asia
- ⊗ Endangered

The stocky, powerful fishing cat lives in freshwater wetlands and tidal mangrove swamps, where it hunts fish and other aquatic animals such as frogs, crabs, crayfish, and even snakes. It swims well, but has few physical adaptations for its way of life—its teeth, for example, are not well suited to seizing slippery fish, and it usually catches prey with its sharp-clawed forepaws.

Margay

Leopardus wiedii

- ↔ 18–31 in (46–79 cm)
- 📍 S. US to Central and South America
- ⊗ Near threatened

Big-eyed and marked with leopardlike clusters of spots, this small cat lives in tropical forests, where it hunts mainly in the trees. It is an unusually agile climber, able to descend head-first down a trunk like a squirrel or hang by its hindfeet from a high branch. It ambushes opossums, young sloths, squirrels, and small birds, and also preys on invertebrates such as large insects and spiders.

Jaguarundi

Puma yagouaroundi

- ↔ 22–30 in (55–77 cm)
- 📍 S. US to South America
- ⊗ Common

The jaguarundi has an unusually long body and short legs for a cat. Widespread across South America in forests, wetlands, and arid scrub, it occurs in several color forms ranging from black to pale gray-brown, to match its habitat. Active by day, it usually hunts on the ground for any small animals it can catch, including large insects, rodents, rabbits, lizards, and ground-feeding birds.

Brown hyena

Hyaena brunnea

- ↔ 5 ft (1.5 m)
- 📍 Southern Africa
- ⊗ Near threatened

Resembling a large dog, but with a long, shaggy, dark brown coat and short back legs, this southern African hyena ranges far into the Kalahari and Namib deserts in search of carrion and occasional small prey. It can scent a carcass from more than 8 miles (13 km) away and is aggressive enough to steal the prey of a leopard. It lives in small clans with various structures, but always including 1–5 females and their offspring.

Spotted hyena

Crocuta crocuta

- ↔ 5 ft (1.5 m)
- 📍 W. to E. and Southern Africa
- ⊗ Common

The biggest and most powerful of the hyenas—with massive jaws and teeth capable of cracking large bones—the spotted hyena is both a scavenger and an accomplished pack-hunting predator. It lives in female-dominated clans with up to 80 members in prey-rich savanna. The clan shares a communal den, and members work together to bring down prey, such as wildebeest, or drive larger predators, such as lions, off their kills. The animal makes



many sounds, including the famous hyena's "laugh," which signifies submission to a senior clan member.